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This holds true from the bottom up. Assume that a man wants to start in business for himself. In order to do this, he must have at least some capital, no matter what the business may be. In most cases, there are only three avenues open to him for obtaining that capital. He can provide it from his own savings, get it by taking in a partner or partners, or borrow it. If the money is his own from the start, the business, too, will be his own. If, however, he has to take in partners, he will own only part of the business and will have to share his profits. And, if he borrows money, the loan must be repaid—almost invariably with interest, which naturally reduces the profits.

Once he has started a business, an individual who is naturally thrifty will have an infinitely greater chance for success than another of equal ability who does not possess this quality. The habitually thrifty person will be able to immediately recognize opportunities for lowering overhead and production costs—and in present-day, highly competitive markets even minor savings can mean a great deal and even represent the difference between a net profit and a net loss.

Beyond this, the person who has formed thrifty habits will always have a fluid reserve to meet contingencies, carry him through slack periods or make it possible for him to expand or make improvements without resorting to borrowing.

The astute individual realizes that such habits as promptness and thrift can greatly help him achieve his goals. He practices promptness and thrift until they become second nature to him—and he reaps rewards from the beneficial force these habits exert on his career.

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But these are by no means the only positive habits that can—and do—provide a powerful propellant to send a man to the top of the success ladder.

One of the most valuable habits any tyro businessman or executive can form is that of taking a last-minute pause to rapidly review his reasoning